"All the News That's Fit to Print"

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, mostly sunny early, afternoon clouds, calm wind, high 61. **Tonight,** cloudy intervals, low 51. **Tomorrow,** mostly sunny, light wind, high 67. Weather map, Page A24.

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Voting for Israel's Future
Election officials measured a large turnout on Tuesday as the country decided whether to keep Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu in power. It was Israel's first election since the Hamas-led attack on Oct. 7, 2023, and the devastating war in Gaza. Page A9.

U.S. Meddling Worries States Ahead of Vote

Preparing for ICE Raids and Ballot Seizures

This article is by ***Richard Fausset****,* ***Zolan Kanno-Youngs*** *and* ***David W. Chen****.*

State and local elections officials regularly plan for floods, fires and computer glitches.

This year, they are teaching poll workers what to do if immigration enforcement officers show up. They are drilling them about the statute that bars federal agents from voting places. They are running through the limits of what federal monitors may and may not do on Election Day.

Much of the preparations for Tuesday can be distilled into one overarching concern — that the Trump administration will somehow attempt to meddle with the voting process or the results. The tricky part, officials said, is predicting what shape that interference might take while also recognizing that it might not materialize at all.

"This is the first time ever that we have had to engage in scenario planning to safeguard against potential federal interference in elections," said Shenna Bellows, the secretary of state in Maine. "It seems like the federal government is now adversarial to the states."

It remains to be seen whether any of these scenarios will play out. Many federal officials have dismissed the idea that agents or soldiers could be sent to the polls, and the courts have blocked most of President Trump's efforts to insert the federal government into state and local election administration.

And some of the country's most prominent voting advocates have sought to assure the public that election administrators are well-prepared to protect the vote. David Becker, a former voting rights lawyer for the Justice Department, said the most chilling possibilities are unlikely to come to pass because the courts would likely block them.

"But election officials feel more comfortable to know they've thought about this, and discussed it," said Mr. Becker, who runs the Center for Election Innovation and Research, a nonpartisan group that works to support election officials in both parties.

Even so, the Trump administration has already taken significant steps to try to shape the voting process this year. Mr. Trump has sought to sow doubt about the security of elections. His administration has demanded that states

Continued on Page A11

FLURRY OF MOVES BY JUSTICE DEPT. SHOWS URGENCY AGAINST TRUMP CRITICS

Blanche Says the Actions Before the Midterms Aren't Retribution

This article is by ***Glenn Thrush****,* ***Alan Feuer*** *and* ***Devlin Barrett****.*

WASHINGTON — Attorney General Todd Blanche has delivered the same message time and again, at turns soothing and combative: The Justice Department is doing nothing out of the ordinary, and nothing remotely improper, in the lead-up to the midterm elections.

"We don't do political paybacks," Mr. Blanche declared last week, after he announced the indictment of a prominent Virginia Democrat on drug-trafficking charges.

"You got to stop it with that!" the usually measured Mr. Blanche said on Sunday, scolding Dana Bash of CNN for suggesting his effort to potentially block certification of Alaska's Senate election to protect the Republican incumbent was undemocratic.

Yet it has become increasingly difficult to reconcile reassurances with reality, critics say.

In recent days Mr. Blanche and his team have announced, unsealed or initiated a succession of headline-grabbing actions certain to placate Mr. Trump's demand for results, many targeting his longtime adversaries or promoting contested claims of election fraud.

That cadence seems to be quickening to a gallop.

On Monday, a federal judge in Washington unsealed new charges against James B. Comey, the third criminal case brought against the former F.B.I. director Mr. Trump openly reviles. If it is sustained in court, the charges open a new lane of criminal inquiry after the department's indictment against Mr. Comey in April for sharing an image of seashells that Trump appointees say was a veiled assassination threat.

"This is a classic flood-the-zone strategy — run so many plays at once that the defense doesn't know where to look," said Greg Rosen, a former federal prosecutor who led the Justice Department section that investigated Trump supporters who ransacked the Capitol on Jan. 6, 2021.

Department officials declined to comment on ongoing investigations or matters before grand juries. But Emily Covington, the agency's spokeswoman, said that

Continued on Page A18

Digital Army Came to Lula's Rescue in Election

Spirited Drive to Keep Bolsonaro Family Out of Power

This article is by ***Ana Ionova****,* ***Adam B. Ellick*** *and* ***Jack Nicas****.*

BRASÍLIA — It started with a WhatsApp channel with a few thousand followers. It exploded into a digital army of 10 million people that helped swing Latin America's biggest election.

President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva of Brazil staged a stunning comeback on Sunday, achieving an unexpected victory over Flávio Bolsonaro, the right-wing challenger whose father tried to stage a coup after losing the last election.

In winning, Mr. Lula did what no other presidential candidate has accomplished in Brazil's history — he won election after finishing second in the first round.

His victory rested, to a significant degree, on social media. A tidal wave of messages, memes and reels flooded Brazil, a chronically online nation of 214 million, and rallied millions of Brazilians with diverging views around a single task: barring the return of the Bolsonaro family to power.

Mr. Lula's win delivered a powerful rebuke to a right-wing movement barreling through Latin America that has been applauded by President Trump. It also deals a blow to Washington's plans for economic and military dominance in the region, extending the reign of the only leader in Latin America — and one of the few globally — who has defied Mr. Trump.

Mr. Lula won by about double the margin he achieved in 2022, when he narrowly defeated Mr. Bolsonaro's father, Jair Bolsonaro.

Continued on Page A7

POLITICIAN FLEES BRAZIL The police had asked Flávio Bolsonaro to cede his passports. PAGE A7

Solving Riddle A.I. Couldn't: Cars and Cats

By CADE METZ

One of the oldest puzzles in artificial intelligence research involves cars and cats. For more than a decade, researchers have wondered why an early Google technology seemed to treat cars like cats and vice versa.

This Google technology, Inception, could reliably identify common objects in digital photographs. But when researchers looked at the myriad mathematical calculations that drove the system, they couldn't make sense of it. The math that identified a car looked a lot like the calculations that recognized a cat.

This month, one A.I. researcher claimed to have solved this riddle. After taking another hard look at the vast array of numbers inside Google's A.I. technology, the researcher, Nick Cammarata, noticed that one of these calculations pinpointed a "V" shape that appeared both at the front of a car and on the face of a cat.

Mr. Cammarata's proposed so-

Continued on Page A17



BRENDAN BANNON FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

"They knew," said Lexi Hawk, at home with her daughter, Bailee. "And they let me live here."

The Toddler Playing in the Radioactive Backyard

Inspections Come After Decades of Inaction

By CHRISTOPHER MAAG

NIAGARA, N.Y. — The first time Lexi Hawk sensed something was wrong, she was playing in her backyard with her toddler, Bailee. Ms. Hawk heard a plane that sounded as if it was right on top of them. She looked and there it was, flying super slow and right above the treetops. It passed over her house again and again.

"I was like, 'What's going on?'" she remembers thinking. "'Are we getting attacked?'"

That was the summer of 2024. A year later, Ms. Hawk and Bailee were outside again when three men pulled up to their house in a truck. One got out and started sweeping a Geiger counter along the grass.

"They told me not to worry, it was probably just a rock," she said. Some rocks, they explained, could have natural, low-level radioactivity. "I was a little concerned."

Then, this summer, after finishing her shift at a hair salon, she drove home to find a crew of men on her property wearing head-to-toe protective suits. One used a little yellow backhoe to dig holes in the yard.

"It was like a horror movie scene," said Ms. Hawk. "It was like driving into a nightmare."

The little blue ranch house in Niagara, N.Y., was supposed to be a suburban oasis for Ms. Hawk,

Continued on Page A20

Roller Coaster Deaths Testing a Limit on Thrills

By JOHN BRANCH

Compared with baseball and apple pie, the roller coaster is the renegade symbol of the carefree American summer.

It is a twisted beacon over the kaleidoscopic amusement-park landscape. It dares us to be daring. Steep drops, high speeds and improbably tight curves force screams from contorted faces and cause butterflies for those crowding to be next.

For the American leisure class, there is no entertainment quite like it. The roller coaster can be a rite of passage for kids and an obsession for adults.

Their continued popularity depends on a mind trick, a bit of dynamic tension — enticing us to strap into something that feels dangerous, maybe unwise, but is actually safe.

"The goal is to flirt with danger without actually experiencing it," said Brian Avery, a University of Florida lecturer who specializes in amusement-park safety. "But occasionally, people are exposed to it, and they're either dying or are being significantly injured as a result of it."



ELIJAH NOUVELAGE/GETTY IMAGES

Goliath, a coaster at Six Flags.

This month, a new round of reckoning has arrived.

On Oct. 12, a man was thrown from his seat, mid-ride, and died on the Goliath coaster at Six Flags Over Georgia. That prompted Six Flags, the chain of amusement parks, to shut down at least nine other coasters across the country for closer inspection. On Friday, Six Flags said it would add seatbelts to existing restraints on the Goliath and several other coasters.

Only weeks earlier, in late September, Six Flags Magic Mountain in Valencia, Calif., permanently closed one of its popular coasters, X2, after years of complaints about its safety. It faced a lawsuit from three riders regarding catastrophic brain injuries, and recently settled a wrongful-death suit involving a 22-year-old man who died a day after riding the coaster in 2022.

Concern over roller-coaster safety is not a new issue. It rises and falls with every technological twist of gut-bending, mind-blowing adaptations. Each generation of coaster becomes higher, faster, steeper, bendier and gnarlier. And maybe more worrisome.

Have roller coasters, finally, gone too far? Have we reached the point where they can't get more thrilling, or death-defying, be-

Continued on Page A21

NATIONAL A10-21, 24

Fishing Trip Ends in ICE Cell
In states like Florida, officers who hand out fishing citations and inspect produce are part of President Trump's deportation campaign. PAGE A10

Latinos Emerge as Vital Bloc
They helped fuel President Trump's return, but Democrats have won back the trust of Hispanic voters. PAGE A16

OBITUARIES B11-12

Chekov From 'Star Trek'
Walter Koenig played a U.S.S. Enterprise navigator on the original series and in films. He was 90. PAGE B12



INTERNATIONAL A4-9

Nine-Ton Chopper vs. a Drone
Militaries around the world assess the efficacy of legacy technologies like attack helicopters in a new era. PAGE A4

Confronting Serbia's Media
Supporters of the movement that won Sunday's election stormed the offices of a pro-government tabloid. PAGE A6

BUSINESS B1-6

Europe's A.I. 'Robogym'
Germany's Neura is at the forefront of efforts to use artificial intelligence in robotics, training machines to become more human. PAGE B1

Fed Expected to Sit on Rates
Inflation is moving in the wrong direction and the labor market is stable, which often means an increase. PAGE B1

SPORTS B7-10

End of Philadelphia Tradition
Villanova, the most prominent program in the Big 5, exposed the reality that nostalgia doesn't pay the bills. PAGE B7

ARTS C1-6

He's Used to Overachieving
Brady Farrar, who was a child star for a season of the reality TV show "Dance Moms," is now 21 and the youngest choreographer in the history of the American Ballet Theater. PAGE C1

'Friends' Sister Shares Story
Mia Perry Bowick, who speaks publicly for the first time in a docuseries about the life and career of her brother, Matthew Perry, joins the film's director to discuss the production. PAGE C1

OPINION A22-23

Bret Stephens PAGE A23



FOOD D1-8

The Trick? Paying for Treats.
It will cost frightening amounts of cash to satisfy the cravings of the goblins and ghosts who will descend upon your doorstep this Halloween. PAGE D1